



Beijing 2008

SPECIAL FEATURE



REUTERS/REINHARD KRAUSE



AFP PHOTO/STEPHEN SHAVER



AP PHOTO/YODO NEWS

Yes, yes, of course, the Beijing Games open at 8 O'clock on the eighth day of the eighth month of the year 2008 in a thunderclap of fireworks (er...the Chinese invented them too). But the 'eight' that has mesmerised the world belongs to an American with an old affinity for water and a newly-sprouted, rather becoming Fu Manchu moustache. This worshipful global chorus around his pursuit of Mark Spitz's record, however, puzzles Michael Phelps: "You guys are the ones talking about it... I haven't said anything about going after any record."

Gee, Michael, the world wants you to win eight golds because it's just an *Olympic* kinda thing to do. China does that to people, makes them think macro and in one mind. They know a few things about collective will here. That's what these Games are based on. For the past seven years, it's all they have thought about. In English, they're calling it "Bejingoism" and in Mandarin, the Chinese don't bother to translate. They just holler "*Jia Yoh, Jia Yoh*", in their deep, rousing national sporting chant. It means 'come on' and they say it gives their athletes "power".

They will probably be chanting for two whole weeks because their eventual goal is to top the gold medal table ahead of the United States and they think 40-odd golds should do it. "We're only interested in gold," shrugs storekeeper Jiang Fengzhen, echoing what one of their foreign rowing coaches was told: "One gold equals a thousand silvers". It is a very heavy load for China's 639 athletes to



ALL GAME:
(Clockwise from left) Olympic posters in Beijing, Chinese athlete Liu Xiang, a ceremony to mark the one year countdown to the Beijing Games



bear. *Xinhua* sports writer Cao Jianjie says, "Home court advantage is a double-edged sword—our athletes are very nervous competing at home." Superstars like NBA basketballer Houston Rockets centre Yao Ming and Athens 100m gold medallist Liu Xiang, live in a fish bowl and Cao says "don't worry" about pressure. Those fretting the most are table tennis players, gymnasts and divers. The race for Aoyun Shoujin (first gold) has turned into a bit-

ter contest between China's shooters and the weightlifters.

To help them soak in the stress, China's coaches have tried to simulate the Beijing Games during training. Noise has been cranked up, families have been invited to watch those athletes who specifically don't want them around during competition and psychologists and Chinese philosophy experts have been summoned. Now the athletes are just about ready to go. Chinese riflewoman

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